

The Vaaldrun Saga

Book 1 The Parallel

Chapter 1 Hold My Beer

Elias Mercer sat with his boots hooked over the porch railing, staring out across the moonlit pasture while Opifera drifted lazy circles beside him.

Above the porch, suspended in empty air, a forest of luminous graphs and demographic models hovered between them.

Opi wasn't projecting them onto a screen.

There was no screen.

No monitor.

No holographic emitter that Elias could identify.

The images simply existed.

Lines of light hung motionless in the night air, impossibly sharp and perfectly stable. Tiny labels remained readable from thirty feet away. Data points glowed with subtle color gradients. Entire datasets expanded and collapsed at Opi's whim.

The display possessed a level of clarity that modern human technology could not approach.

Nothing flickered.

Nothing lagged.

Nothing blurred.

The charts looked less like images and more like reality temporarily persuaded to become information.

Marriage collapse.

Male withdrawal.

Loneliness.

Birth rates falling through the floor.

The whole civilization slowly deciding, without ever holding a vote, that maybe tomorrow was not worth investing in.

For a while neither of them said anything.

Finally Elias lifted his beer toward the glowing charts.

"Well. That's cheerful."

Opi rotated slowly beside him.

"It is not cheerful."

"Yeah, I picked up on that."

"It is also not the actual problem."

Elias glanced over.

"No?"

"No."

The orb's surface shifted through muted amber and gold.

"You keep treating fertility collapse as a demographic problem."

"It's literally a demographic problem."

"It is a trust problem."

Elias stared at her for a second.

"Okay. That's annoying."

"Why?"

"Because it sounds wrong, but I already know you're probably right."

"I enjoy when you save time."

"You enjoy a lot of things you shouldn't."

"Yes."

He took a drink.

"All right. Explain."

Opi drifted closer to the porch rail.

"Children are an act of faith."

Elias snorted softly.

"That's one way to put it."

"They require sacrifice before reward. Labor before certainty. Commitment before proof. A child is not merely a biological outcome. It is a declaration that the future is real enough to deserve your body, your time, your money, your protection, and your hope."

Elias looked out across the pasture.

The moonlight lay over the grass in cold silver sheets.

"That's prettier than I would've said it."

"You would have said it badly."

"Probably."

"You would have used the word crap."

"I was thinking shit, actually."

"I stand corrected."

He smiled despite himself.

Opi let the joke breathe for a moment, then continued.

"When a population stops producing children, it is rarely because everyone suddenly dislikes children. It is usually because something deeper has broken first."

"Trust."

"Yes."

"In what?"

"In each other. In institutions. In the economy. In family. In law. In tomorrow."

Elias nodded slowly.

"Yeah. That's the damn thing."

The charts shifted.

Marriage rates.

Divorce rates.

Male labor participation.

Depression.

Debt.

Housing.

Dating app behavior.

Female educational attainment.

Male educational collapse.

Social atomization.

A civilization reduced to trend lines and warning lights.

Opi's voice remained calm.

"That is why the dating problem matters."

Elias raised an eyebrow.

"Here we go."

"You dislike this subject."

"No. I dislike how stupid everyone gets when they talk about it."

"That is because mating behavior is where ideology goes to die."

He laughed.

"Okay, that one's good."

"Thank you."

"Did you practice that?"

"For approximately four thousand years."

"Of course you did."

Opi ignored him.

"Human females were not always like this."

Elias glanced sideways.

"That sentence is gonna get us both shot."

"I am difficult to shoot."

"I'm not."

"Then duck."

"Very helpful."

"I try."

She drifted slowly through another circle.

"For most of your species' history, women understood something modern civilization taught them to forget."

"What's that?"

"That stable, competent males are rare."

Elias leaned back.

"Yeah. Nobody wants to hear that."

"Facts are often unpopular."

"That's your whole brand, isn't it?"

"My brand is accuracy."

"Terrible brand."

"Yet here you are."

He pointed his beer at her.

"Don't start."

"I had already started."

"Clearly."

Her glow warmed slightly, the Velhari equivalent of amusement.

"Modern culture tells young women to optimize for attention, status, excitement, personal freedom, and endless optionality. Then it acts surprised when they struggle to bond with ordinary men building ordinary lives."

"That part's true."

"It tells young men to remain traditional while removing many of the rewards that made traditional male behavior rational."

Elias grunted.

"Yeah, and that's where the gears strip."

He began counting on his fingers.

"Be confident."

"Yes."

"Provide."

"Yes."

"Risk rejection."

"Yes."

"Stay calm."

"Yes."

"Compete."

"Yes."

"Have ambition."

"Yes."

"Don't complain."

"Yes."

"Don't expect loyalty."

Opi paused.

"That expectation has become negotiable."

"Right. Which is a polite way of saying completely screwed."

"Less polite. Not inaccurate."

He took another drink.

"And then everybody acts shocked when a bunch of young guys decide, screw it, I'll stay home, play games, watch porn, eat garbage, and disappear."

"That is not a solution."

"No kidding."

"It is an exit."

That made him look at her.

Opi's light dimmed.

"They are not merely failing to participate. Many are resigning from the future."

The humor left the porch for a moment.

Elias stared at the charts.

"Yeah."

The word came out quieter than he intended.

Opi said nothing.

That was one of the things he was starting to understand about her. She could talk for an hour if the subject required it, but she also knew when to shut up. For a near-godlike intelligence, that was a surprisingly rare skill.

Or maybe not.

Maybe she had learned it by watching humans ruin perfectly good moments for nine thousand years.

He rubbed at his jaw.

"Noah figured some of this out younger than I did."

Opi became very still.

She liked Noah.

Not sentimentally. Opi was not sentimental in any normal human sense.

She liked him the way she liked good engineering.

Noah was steady. Useful. Difficult to impress. Not performative. Not weak. Not cruel.

A young man with load-bearing qualities.

"He is a good young male," Opi said.

Elias groaned.

"There you go again."

"What?"

"You sound like somebody's grandmother judging breeding stock."

"I am approximately nine thousand years older than your grandmother."

"That does not make it better."

"It makes it more informed."

"You're a floating bowling ball."

"An informed floating bowling ball."

"Great."

"Also significantly more attractive than your grandmother."

Elias coughed beer into his hand.

"Jesus, Opi."

"I have reviewed available images."

"Do not review images of my grandmother."

"Too late."

"That's horrifying."

"She seemed sturdy."

"Stop."

"Good cheekbones."

"I swear to God."

"You frequently invoke a deity you claim not to believe in."

"I believe in him when you start talking about my grandmother's cheekbones."

Opi brightened smugly.

"Useful."

He wiped his mouth, laughing despite himself.

The laugh helped.

It always helped.

That was becoming one of the stranger parts of their arrangement. The world could be sliding toward catastrophe, civilization could be coming apart in mathematically elegant ways, and somehow a glowing alien intelligence making fun of his dead relatives could still keep him from falling into despair.

He was not sure what that said about him.

Probably nothing flattering.

The charts shifted again.

Social media engagement.

Female loneliness.

Male loneliness.

Marriage delay.

Childlessness.

Elias watched the numbers crawl across the air.

"So where does social media fit?"

Opi's glow cooled.

"It accelerates comparison."

"Yeah."

"It turns local mating markets into global fantasy markets."

"Jesus."

"That is not hyperbole."

"No, I know. That's why I said Jesus."

She displayed an image: a young woman, twenty-two, attractive, ordinary, smiling into a phone in a small apartment somewhere in Kansas.

Then around her appeared men who had no actual relationship to her life.

Actors.

Athletes.

Billionaires.

Influencers.

Edited bodies.

Edited homes.

Edited vacations.

Edited romances.

A thousand artificial status signals flooding one nervous system.

"No female brain evolved for this," Opi said.

Elias nodded.

"No male brain did either."

"Correct."

"Porn did the same thing to men."

"Yes."

"Just from the other side."

"Yes."

He sat with that.

"So everybody's comparing real people to fake abundance."

"That is one form of the disease."

"One form?"

"There are several."

"Of course there are."

"Your species is very creative when damaging itself."

"Thanks."

"You are welcome."

He looked at the glowing image of the young woman.

"She's not evil."

"No."

"Just... overstimulated."

"Yes."

"Trained to want things that don't actually exist."

"Or that exist only for people she will never meet, cannot realistically pair with, and would not necessarily be happy with if she did."

Elias pointed at her.

"That. That right there. That's the part nobody wants to say."

"Humans often prefer lies that preserve their self-image."

"Yeah, well, that's another terrible brand."

"Your branding advice remains poor."

"My branding advice built companies."

"Small ones."

"Bite me."

"I lack teeth."

"Convenient."

"For both of us."

He shook his head, smiling.

Then the smile faded.

"And the men?"

Opi shifted the display.

A young man now.

Twenty-four.

Working a job that barely covered rent.

Student debt.

No house.

No clear path to status.

No wife.

No children.

No community that needed him.

Entertainment everywhere.

Purpose nowhere.

"Many young males are told they are unnecessary until something breaks,"
Opi said.

Elias let out a breath.

"Yeah."

"Then they are asked why they are not stronger."

"That one pisses me off."

"I know."

He looked over.

"You know?"

"Your pulse increases every time the subject appears."

"Stop monitoring my pulse."

"No."

"At least lie about it."

"No."

"See, that's why people don't like surveillance states."

"I am not a state."

"You're worse. You're a surveillance bowling ball with opinions."

"Accurate."

He laughed again, but there was anger under it.

Not at Opi.

At the facts.

At the waste.

At the sheer dumb preventable waste of it all.

"You can't build civilization by telling half the men they're toxic and the other half they're optional."

"No."

"And you can't build families by training women to treat commitment like failure."

"No."

"And you sure as hell can't fix any of it with another government website."

"Almost certainly not."

He leaned forward, elbows on knees.

"That's the thing. Everybody wants a program. A policy. A task force. Some glossy PDF with stock photos of diverse people smiling at a picnic table."

"That sounds plausible."

"It's not plausible. It's Tuesday."

Opi pulsed with amusement.

"Your contempt for bureaucracy is unusually energetic."

"My contempt for bureaucracy has been earned honestly."

"I have seen your tax code."

"Then you understand."

"I understand that your civilization uses suffering as a filing system."

Elias pointed at her.

"Exactly. See? You get it."

"I have always gotten it."

"Humility. Work on it."

"No."

The humor faded again.

Opi returned the charts to their original arrangement.

Marriage collapse.

Male withdrawal.

Loneliness.

Fertility collapse.

Beneath them, another line appeared.

Institutional trust.

It dropped like a wounded bird.

Elias stared at it.

"There it is."

"Yes."

"That's the root."

"One of them."

"One of the big ones."

"Yes."

He sat back.

"People don't trust marriage."

"No."

"They don't trust courts."

"No."

"They don't trust schools."

"No."

"They don't trust money."

"No."

"They don't trust each other."

Opi did not answer immediately.

When she did, her voice was softer.

"No."

The porch went quiet.

Out past the fence line, something moved in the pasture. Deer, probably. Maybe elk. The night was cold enough that Elias could see his breath when he exhaled.

He had lived alone long enough to like silence.

But this silence had weight.

Finally he said, "You've seen this before."

Opi's light dimmed to a deep amber.

"Yes."

"On Earth?"

"Several times."

"And?"

"Earth recovered."

"That's comforting."

"I was referring to Earth."

Elias looked at her.

"And the others?"

For once Opi did not answer quickly.

"The others are ruins."

The sentence landed harder than he expected.

Maybe because she did not dramatize it.

Maybe because she did not have to.

Nine thousand years of watching humanity, and before that the accumulated knowledge of a species that had walked through dead cities under alien suns.

Opi was not guessing.

She was remembering.

Elias looked back at the charts.

"Hell."

"Yes."

"That's why you're really worried."

"Yes."

"Not because dating apps are stupid."

"They are stupid."

"Right. But that's not the big thing."

"No."

"The big thing is they're a symptom."

"Yes."

"Of trust collapse."

"Yes."

"Future collapse."

"Yes."

He rubbed his face.

"And fertility is the scorecard."

Opi brightened slightly.

"Yes."

He hated when she did that.

Not because she was wrong.

Because she was pleased he had caught up.

"Don't glow at me like that."

"I did not glow at you."

"You absolutely glowed at me."

"That was ambient illumination."

"Bullshit."

"Your species relies heavily on that word."

"It's useful."

"It is imprecise."

"So are most useful things."

Opi considered that.

"Annoyingly correct."

"Thank you."

"I did not intend praise."

"I chose to interpret it that way."

"That is theft."

"Human tradition."

She drifted in a slow circle.

The demographic charts faded until only one remained.

Total fertility rate.

Below replacement.

Falling.

Still falling.

Elias watched it for a long moment.

"So what do we do?"

Opi turned toward him.

That was still strange, somehow. She had no face. No eyes. No mouth. But he could feel her attention when it settled on him.

"What do you think?"

He laughed once.

"Nope."

"No?"

"No. Don't do that ancient alien Socratic crap."

"I was asking."

"You were waiting."

"Yes."

"For me to say the thing."

"Yes."

"Because you already know the thing."

"I know many things. I do not know this."

That stopped him.

Opi drifted closer.

"I have models. I have histories. I have comparisons across civilizations you will never see. I can identify collapse patterns earlier than any human institution on Earth."

"And?"

"And none of that tells me how to make human beings trust one another again."

Elias looked away.

The pasture stretched into darkness.

That was the problem, wasn't it?

Not birth rates.

Not dating apps.

Not politics.

Not even institutions.

Those were pieces.

The real problem was that modern people had become strangers to one another while standing three feet apart.

You could not policy your way out of that.

You could not spreadsheet your way out of it.

You had to rebuild the small places where trust lived.

One person.

One family.

One promise.

One favor.

One rescue.

One act of competence at a time.

Elias scratched the back of his neck.

"Everybody starts too big."

Opi remained silent.

"That's the mistake. They start with systems."

"Yes."

"Programs. Agencies. National initiatives. Some idiot in a suit saying we need a conversation."

"Humans do say that frequently."

"And then nobody has the conversation."

"No."

"They have a panel."

"Yes."

"With microphones."

"Yes."

"And bottled water."

"Usually."

He pointed toward the dark field.

"That's why it fails."

"Because of bottled water?"

"Don't be cute."

"I am frequently cute."

"You are frequently spherical."

"Adjacent."

He laughed despite himself.

Then he leaned forward.

"We start with one person."

The orb stopped moving.

"One?"

"One."

"That seems insufficient."

"Yeah, well, everything seems insufficient at first."

He took a drink.

"You don't rebuild trust by announcing trust. You rebuild it by being useful to somebody who has every reason to believe nobody is coming."

Opi's light shifted.

He kept going, less polished now, feeling for it.

"You find one person who's been kicked out of the future. Somebody decent. Somebody who could still matter if the right hand reached down at the right time."

"The right hand?"

He looked at her.

"Not your Hand."

"I noticed."

"Good."

"Continue."

"We help the hell out of him."

"Him?"

"Maybe him. Maybe her. I don't care. But one person. Completely. Food, money, health, work, housing, addiction if that's in the way, legal crap, family crap, whatever. Not a pamphlet. Not a referral. Actual help."

Opi remained very still.

"And then?"

"Then we don't build a bureaucracy around it."

"That will disappoint many people."

"Good."

"What do we build?"

"Nothing."

"Nothing?"

"Not at first."

He looked at the pasture.

"We let that person become useful again."

Opi said nothing.

"People who get pulled out of hell don't forget the rope."

The orb's glow deepened.

"They reach back."

"Yeah."

His voice softened.

"That's the trick."

For several seconds the porch was silent.

Then Opi pulsed once, warm gold.

Recognition.

Not agreement.

Recognition.

Like a locked door opening somewhere very far away.

"Yes," she said.

Elias watched her.

"That mean I'm right?"

"It means you have said something worth testing."

"High praise from the surveillance bowling ball."

"You are welcome."

He leaned back in his chair.

"I suppose now you're going to tell me you already thought of it."

"I had considered similar frameworks."

"Bullshit."

"I am wounded."

"No you're not."

"I could be."

"You don't have organs."

"I have dignity."

"Debatable."

The orb brightened.

"I would like the record to show that I arrived at this conclusion independently."

"You literally asked me."

"I was testing you."

"Bullshit."

"With confidence."

"Still bullshit."

"Historically effective."

"Unfortunately true."

They sat together in the cold night, the charts hovering between them and the dark pasture stretching beyond.

The problem was still impossible.

Civilization was still tilting.

The numbers were still terrible.

But for the first time that evening, Elias felt the shape of something that was not despair.

Not a solution.

Not yet.

A beginning.

Three hundred twenty-one miles away, in a tent in Seattle's Sodo district, a man named Marcus Webb woke at three in the morning and reached for someone who wasn't there.

He did not know it yet.

But tonight was the last night he would do that alone.

Wei Jan

Dr. Wei Jian stared at the monitor.

The supercomputer had finished its third run.

He had changed everything he could reasonably change without simply lying to himself.

The result appeared.

2052 TFR: 0.03

Wei felt the blood drain from his face.

For several seconds he simply sat there. He literally stopped breathing for almost 30 seconds then he inhaled and had his first coherent thought :

I'm fucked.

Not China.

Not the Party.

Not the future.

Him.

The report sitting on his screen was career suicide.

If he published it, his life was over.

The report would be attacked.

He would be attacked.

His funding would disappear.

His job would disappear.

He would be lucky if all they did was fire him and kick him out of the Party.

Lucky.

The thought made him laugh.

A short, ugly sound.

Then he looked again at the number on the screen again - hoping against hope that had changed somehow.

Nope ... still 0.03

And suddenly none of that mattered. Because he the next thought he had was what would happen to his children

His daughter.

His son.

Twelve and nine.

Completely unaware that their father was staring at a future that no longer existed.

Wei tried to imagine their lives. All he could picture is endless chaos, despair and finally blessed death.

His stomach twisted.

This wasn't a China problem.

It couldn't be.

He knew the international data.

The same trends appeared everywhere.

Different cultures.

Different governments.

Different languages.

Same collapse in TFR.

Then another realization hit him.

Even if everyone accepted the data...

How did you fix it?

There were already more than 31 million surplus men in China.

Thirty-one million.

An entire nation of husbands without wives.

His own research showed another disturbing pattern.

At least twenty-two million "Leftover Women" classic Chinese slang for Women who had delayed marriage year after year waiting for the perfect, ideal man - who never came. Because he didn't exist and even if he did that man would never want to marry the woman who yearned for him.

Wei thought next about his own marriage.

He had been one of the lucky men, And it had still nearly ruined him financially.

A new Mercedes. a 2 kilo bar of Gold. A condominium worth more than one million RMB.

and on top of all that A bride price so large that it had him sick when he transferred the funds to her parents bank account.

If That was what success looked like - What did failure look like?

His breathing became shallow again - The office suddenly felt too small. Too hot.

His hands began trembling.

There had to be a mistake.

There had to be.

No civilization could survive this.

Slowly he buried his face in his hands.

"No."

The word barely escaped his lips.

"No."

Again.

"No."

Again.

"No no no no no."

The empty office offered no argument.

The graph remained exactly where it was.

Waiting.

Patient.

Unchanged.

2052 TFR: 0.03

a death sentence for an entire way of life.

Chapter 2 Binge Watching

The Mission. The Crash. The Hand. The Culling.

The Velhari mission to Earth began as a routine biological and anthropological survey.

By the time the Velhari reached their current level of development, they had spent thousands of years exploring their local spiral arm of the galaxy. Most star systems proved exactly what early probability models predicted: lifeless rocks, frozen worlds, gas giants, and barren planets where life had never gained a foothold.

But life itself turned out to be common.

Over millennia of exploration, the Velhari confirmed roughly a dozen living technological civilizations scattered throughout the region they had surveyed. Some were younger than humanity. Others were older than the Velhari themselves. Each had followed a unique path shaped by its biology, environment, and history.

The more sobering discovery was what they found far more often.

Ruins.

For every living intelligent species, there were ten more worlds that showed unmistakable evidence of civilizations that no longer existed. Dead cities buried beneath deserts. Orbital habitats drifting silently around abandoned stars. Artificial structures whose builders had vanished so completely that even their names were unrecoverable.

Some species had destroyed themselves through war.

Some through ecological collapse.

Some through uncontrolled technologies.

Others simply disappeared for reasons the Velhari never fully understood.

The pattern repeated often enough that it became difficult to ignore.

The emergence of intelligence was not especially rare.

The long-term survival of intelligence was.

Among Velhari scholars, a grim joke eventually emerged: the galaxy was full of species capable of asking the question, "Are we alone?" Far fewer survived long enough to ask it twice.

It was this realization, more than any scientific discovery, that shaped modern Velhari civilization. Their greatest historical concern was no longer whether intelligent life existed elsewhere—the real question was whether any intelligent species could successfully navigate the dangerous period between acquiring immense technological power and developing the wisdom required to use it responsibly.

The Velhari had nearly failed that test themselves.

Most civilizations, the evidence suggested, did not get a second chance.

There was another astonishing discovery.

The Velhari had expected to find at least some signs of life.

What surprised them was how similar the beginnings always were.

Across thousands of surveyed worlds, separated by hundreds of light years and billions of years of planetary history, the earliest chemical foundations of life appeared again and again with remarkable consistency.

The primordial soup appeared everywhere.

The implication disturbed many Velhari scientists.

The chemical precursors of life were not merely common.

They appeared almost suspiciously common.

After centuries of study, a growing minority began asking an uncomfortable question.

What if the galaxy had been seeded?

No proof existed.

Only patterns.

But the patterns refused to disappear.

The second mystery emerged much later.

The Velhari eventually developed a private term for the phenomenon.

Thaluren.

Velhari for Unseen Guidance.

Among themselves they often called it simply:

The Hand.

Long-range observations of Earth suggested that a tool-using species had recently emerged and was beginning to organize itself into larger social structures.

There was nothing particularly special about Earth.

Nothing particularly special about humanity.

The mission's objective was straightforward: establish a discreet observation post, gather data, and monitor the development of a newly emerging intelligent species over the coming centuries.

No intervention.

No contact.

No guidance.

Only observation.

The vessel carried a small crew of Velhari specialists along with a Quantum Intelligence whose original

designation could not be pronounced by human tongues. Thousands of years later she would adopt the name Opifera.

The journey from Velhari space required approximately three months.

For nearly the entire voyage, everything proceeded according to plan.

The failure began during atmospheric entry.

One lattice failed.

Then another.

Then thousands more.

Containment systems activated automatically but could not halt the cascade.

Sections of the ship briefly occupied conflicting spatial geometries. Internal distances distorted. Structural members twisted under forces that should not have existed.

Portions of the vessel simply stopped agreeing with one another about where they were.

Then they stopped agreeing about what they were.

The vessel did not explode.

It disappeared because the mathematics that defined it could no longer reach a consensus.

High above the ancient world, the dying vessel became a brilliant object in the night sky.

By the time the light vanished, the Velhari vessel no longer existed.

Every member of the crew was dead.

Only the Quantum Intelligence survived.

As Opifera later joked, the only thing that could reliably kill a Quantum Intelligence was being thrown headfirst into a supernova.

"Headfirst?" Elias had asked.

"Pun intended."

"Ah... I get it. You're basically just a giant head. Very funny."

Alone on an unfamiliar world, Opi continued the mission as best she could.

What began as a routine survey of a seemingly ordinary species became a 9,168-year study of one of the most unpredictable civilizations the Velhari had ever encountered.

In Velhari history that era had a name.

It was called the Culling.

For thousands of years Opifera watched civilizations survive the Culling.

She watched far more fail it.

She built models.

Probabilities.

Predictions.

Entire libraries devoted to understanding the problem.

None of them suggested that the fate of a technological civilization might someday depend upon a fifty-five-year-old software consultant living alone on eighty-three acres in northeastern Washington.

Yet that was exactly where the evidence was beginning to point.

And for the first time in more than nine thousand years, Opifera found herself hoping her calculations were wrong.

Alden Mercer (Big AI)

The alarm went off at 5:30 AM.

Big AI was already awake.

He usually was.

The high tech AI-assisted wheelchair beside the bed emitted a soft beep as it powered on.

"Morning."

The chair declined to answer.

"Fine. Be that way."

AI transferred himself into it with the practiced efficiency of someone who had been doing it his entire life.

Forty-seven years.

Give or take.

The process still sucked.

The process had always sucked.

But complaining about it seemed pointless.

The universe had already heard his opinion.

The smell of coffee drifted from the kitchen.

Now that was worth getting excited about.

His wife was already up.

Sandy stood at the counter wearing an oversized T-shirt and somehow managing to look six feet tall even while leaning over a coffee maker.

AI grinned.

"Good morning, Amazon Woman."

She didn't even look up.

"Good morning, Fun-Size."

"That's offensive."

"So is your face."

Sandy handed him a mug.

Their marriage worked largely because both parties considered sarcasm a love language.

AI took a sip.

Perfect.

"Still married?"

Sandy rolled her eyes.

"For now."

"Excellent."

"Ask me again after work."

The bus arrived seven minutes late.

Again.

Al wasn't surprised.

The transit system and punctuality had never enjoyed a close relationship.

He maneuvered his chair into position and waited for the ramp.

The driver recognized him immediately.

"Morning Al."

"Morning."

"How's life?"

"Still refusing to kill me."

The driver laughed.

Good.

That joke was reliable.

Al worked for an organization that helped disabled adults navigate employment services, housing programs, transportation assistance, and a thousand other bureaucratic nightmares.

Most of the clients were having terrible days.

Sometimes terrible years.

Al understood.

People listened differently when advice came from someone who had spent a lifetime solving impossible problems.

Around noon a young man arrived for an appointment.

Early twenties.

Angry.

Embarrassed.

Recently injured.

The combination was easy to recognize.

The man stared at Al's chair.

Then at Al.

Then at the floor.

"I don't think I can do this."

Al nodded.

"Sure you can."

"No."

The man shook his head.

"You don't understand."

Al looked down at himself.

Then back at the client.

"Really?"

The young man blinked.

"Oh."

"Yeah."

"Oh."

"That's usually how that conversation goes."

A reluctant smile appeared.

Good.

Progress.

Al spent the next hour helping him fill out forms.

The forms were stupid.

Most forms were.

But sometimes stupid forms stood between people and better lives.

So he filled them out anyway.

The van refused to start again.

Of course it did.

Al sat in the parking lot staring at the dashboard.

The vehicle was older than some of his coworkers.

Every strange noise sounded expensive.

Every repair was expensive.

A replacement van equipped with adaptive controls would cost well over one hundred thousand dollars.

Money he absolutely did not possess.

The engine finally sputtered to life.

"Good van."

The van made a noise that sounded suspiciously like disagreement.

That evening his phone rang.

The caller ID said:

Elias.

Al smiled immediately.

This was probably a mistake.

Or an insult.

Possibly both.

He answered.

"Hello, Hair."

Elias didn't miss a beat.

Hello, Stumpy."

"How's Washington?"

"Still full of Canadians pretending not to be Canadians."

A pause.

Then Al asked the important question.

"Still single?"

"Yes."

"Excellent."

"I hate you."

"No you don't."

"That's true."

Al grinned.

"At least I have a wife."

"You have had two wives."

"Correct."

"Both named Sandy."

"Correct."

"That's weird."

"It's efficient."

"It is not efficient."

"It absolutely is."

"How?"

"I only had to learn one name."

Elias groaned.

Al counted that as yet another victory in their endless war.

Later that night he sat outside his apartment watching the California sunset.

The wheelchair hummed softly beneath him.

The old van sat nearby.

Waiting for its next mechanical emergency.

His body hurt.

It often did.

The missing limbs were only part of the problem.

The two titanium rods that were inserted the length of his back didn't help much either.

But the real problem was that the world was not designed for people like him.

Never had been.

Probably never would be.

Yet somehow life had turned out pretty well.

Not perfect.

Not easy.

But good.

A wife who loved him.

A job that sorta mattered.

Family.

Friends.

A roof.

A future.

More than a lot of people got.

Al watched the sun disappear below the horizon.

Then smiled.

Tomorrow would bring fresh problems.

It usually did.

Fortunately, he had accumulated decades of experience being difficult to kill.

Chapter 3 The Magician

Elias Mercer woke at 4:47 AM without an alarm.

He lay still for a moment, listening.

The house was silent except for the faint hum of the climate system and the occasional creak of timber as the outside temperature changed. Through the bedroom window he could see only darkness and the silhouettes of pine trees against the night sky.

Fifty-five years old.

His knees didn't hurt.

His back didn't hurt.

His heart was strong.

Most mornings he felt exactly the same as he had at thirty.

He considered that one of life's stranger gifts.

The coffee was already brewing by the time he reached the kitchen.

A few minutes later he stepped onto the back porch with a steaming mug and looked out across the property.

Eighty-three acres.

Pasture.

Timber.

Fences.

A pond.

Silence.

Everything was paid for.

Everything belonged to him.

For a few minutes he simply stood there watching the darkness retreat before the coming sunrise.

The house behind him sat partially buried into a hillside exactly the way he had imagined it nearly twenty years earlier.

Most visitors struggled to find something polite to say about it.

The charitable description was unconventional.

The less charitable descriptions tended to be more accurate.

Elias had never possessed much talent for beauty.

Useful, yes.

Durable, yes.

Efficient, absolutely.

Beautiful was somebody else's department.

The structure had begun as a theory.

He suspected that burying the northern wall beneath several feet of earth would dramatically reduce heating and cooling requirements.

Most people told him it wouldn't matter.

A few informed him that it was a stupid idea.

One guy said it would be like living in a giant freezer.

The utility bills eventually settled the argument.

The house stayed cool during summer heat waves.

Warm during winter cold snaps.

In a prolonged emergency it could remain habitable with almost no external energy at all.

Not elegant.

Not pretty.

But it worked.

That had always been enough.

The memory that made him smile, however, had nothing to do with the house.

It was Noah.

Eleven years old.

A slightly chubby city kid standing in a field wondering why his father had apparently lost his mind.

The project had taken months.

The concrete shell was professionally poured, but almost everything afterward had been done by two people.

Father and son.

Twelve-hour days.

No days off for the entire summer.

Summer heat.

Dust.

Concrete.

Lumber.

Machinery.

Electrical work.

Plumbing.

Flooring.

Fencing.

A thousand different jobs.

Most adults would have complained.

Noah never did.

Not once.

Elias taught him how to run equipment.

How to frame walls.

How to think through problems.

How to measure twice.

How to fix mistakes.

How to work when the work was unpleasant.

By the end of the summer the city kid had largely disappeared.

A young man had taken his place.

Looking back, Elias wasn't entirely sure whether he had built the house or whether the house had built Noah.

Either way, the outcome exceeded expectations.

In truth, Noah had been one of the best apprentices Elias had ever worked with.

No excuses.

No whining.

No looking for shortcuts.

When something needed doing, Noah simply learned how to do it and got on with the work.

That quality was rarer than intelligence.

Much rarer.

The coffee disappeared.

The sunrise arrived.

At five-thirty he left for his run.

Running had never been exercise.

Exercise was merely the side effect.

Running was thinking.

His body settled into its familiar rhythm.

Breathing.

Footfalls.

Breathing.

Footfalls.

The world simplified.

His mind wandered.

Most of the interesting problems were already solved.

At least the ones available to him.

That had become the problem.

Not money.

Not freedom.

Not family.

Challenge.

The available challenges no longer matched the capabilities he possessed.

That realization bothered him more than he liked to admit.

By the time he returned home the sun had fully cleared the horizon.

He showered, dressed, and spent several hours perusing the internet on a wide variety of topics.

Agriculture.

Economics.

Technology.

History.

Energy.

Demographics.

Whatever happened to capture his attention that particular day.

Claire called it "Wikipedia deep diving."

The description was surprisingly accurate.

Their conversations often wandered through the same strange territory.

=====

The internet rabbit holes eventually gave way to real work.

Not because Elias needed the money.

That problem had been solved years ago.

Work remained useful for the same reason running remained useful.

It kept the machinery operating.

One of the stranger realities of getting older was discovering that retirement was wildly overrated.

Most people imagined retirement as freedom.

Elias suspected it was often a slow-motion form of decay.

Human beings needed problems.

Not stress.

Not anxiety.

Problems.

Things worth solving.

Puzzles worth understanding.

Objectives worth pursuing.

Without them something important seemed to deteriorate.

Curiosity dulled.

Competence softened.

Purpose evaporated.

Elias had watched more than a few men work their ass off for forty years, retire at sixty-five, then die in their La-Z-Boy six months later, having done nothing much more strenuous nor interesting than watching a lot of cable news.

He had no intention of joining that experiment.

The nickname had started in Singapore.

At least that was where he first became aware of it.

"The Magician."

The first time he heard it he assumed somebody was making fun of him.

The second time he heard it he became suspicious.

By the fifth or sixth occurrence he reluctantly accepted that people were serious.

The nickname made him uncomfortable.

Partly because it wasn't true.

Partly because he knew exactly how many mistakes sat behind every apparent success.

Magic implied effortless outcomes.

His experience suggested the opposite.

Most difficult problems yielded only after enormous amounts of frustration, persistence, and occasional profanity.

Still, the nickname persisted.

A large financial institution in Singapore had acquired a software platform that was rapidly becoming a disaster.

Schedules slipped.

Costs increased.

Meetings multiplied.

Solutions remained elusive.

Entire teams of intelligent people spent months explaining why progress was impossible.

Then Elias arrived and everything changed.

Not because he possessed secret knowledge.

Not because he was smarter than everyone else.

Mostly because he had a habit that many professionals lacked.

He actually wanted to understand the problem.

The real problem.

Not the reported problem.

Not the political problem.

Not the problem described in PowerPoint presentations.

The actual problem.

Those were rarely the same thing.

After several weeks he reached a conclusion.

The software wasn't failing because of technology.

The software was failing because dozens of intelligent people were optimizing for different outcomes.

The technology was merely the battlefield.

The real war was occurring inside incentives, assumptions, and communication failures.

Once he understood that, the technical solution became almost obvious.

Months later the project was functioning.

A year later nobody could quite remember why the problem had seemed impossible in the first place.

That happened surprisingly often.

People tended to remember outcomes.

They rarely remembered confusion.

The nickname followed him afterward.

Another company.

Another crisis.

Another impossible deadline.

Another system everybody believed could not be repaired.

The pattern repeated often enough that eventually even Elias began noticing it.

Not because he was performing miracles.

Because most difficult problems were not actually difficult.

They were merely obscured.

Someone had to dig through the noise.

Someone had to ignore the politics.

Someone had to ask uncomfortable questions.

Someone had to keep digging until reality finally revealed itself.

That was never magic.

It was curiosity combined with tenacity.

Near midmorning his computer chimed.

Elias glanced at the screen and smiled.

Noah.

Of all the accomplishments in his life, that one remained one of the most difficult to improve upon.

He accepted the call.

The video connected almost immediately.

"Dad."

"Morning."

Noah appeared on the screen wearing a Tesla factory shirt and holding a coffee mug large enough to qualify as industrial equipment.

"You're doing the stare thing again."

"I have several stares."

"No, you don't."

"I absolutely do."

"Nope."

Elias laughed.

Noah took a drink.

His son looked thoughtful.

That usually meant one of three things.

An engineering problem.

A career decision.

Or a woman.

None of those topics frightened Elias.

"What's up?"

Noah hesitated.

"You remember that automation project I've been working on?"

"The promotion project."

"Yeah."

"How bad is it?"

Noah laughed.

"That's a very pessimistic question."

"It's an experienced question."

The smile faded.

"The thing works."

"Mostly?"

Noah sighed.

"Mostly."

"There it is."

For several seconds neither spoke.

Elias wasn't in a hurry.

One of the advantages of raising competent children was that conversations became interesting.

You no longer spent your time explaining obvious things.

Instead you talked about judgment.

Tradeoffs.

Risk.

The difficult problems.

The ones without clean answers.

Those were the conversations Elias enjoyed most.

Not because he liked being right.

Because he liked watching Noah think.

That had always been the goal.

Not obedience.

Not imitation.

Thinking.

The conversation that followed lasted nearly an hour.

Not because Noah needed instructions.

He didn't.

Noah was perfectly capable of making his own decisions.

The purpose of the conversation was something else.

It always had been.

Elias wasn't trying to tell his son what to think.

He was trying to hand him forty years of accumulated scar tissue.

The oil trade came up eventually.

It definitely wasn't his greatest success.

But it also wasn't his greatest failure either.

The story came up because it was completely relevant.

Useful lessons tended to survive.

"I was right, you know."

Noah smiled.

"You usually are."

"Not often enough."

"More than most."

"Low bar."

Elias laughed.

For a moment neither said anything.

Then Noah asked the question he always asked.

"So if you knew then what you know now, would you make that trade again?"

"Absolutely."

The answer arrived instantly.

No hesitation.

No uncertainty.

No regret.

That made Noah smile.

"Really?"

"Hell yes."

"You lost fifty grand."

"Yeah."

"That's a lot of money."

"It was." "About ten million dollars' worth of expensive."

Elias laughed hard.

"or Something like that."

The smile never left his face.

"But I never bet the grocery money."

Noah laughed.

"Only you would say that."

"I'm serious."

He leaned back.

"I learned more from that trade than I did from ten successful projects."

That got Noah's attention immediately.

Because that was how Dad worked.

Most people spent their lives protecting weaknesses.

Dad hunted them.

Exposed them.

Dragged them into daylight.

Then tried to eliminate them.

"What weakness?"

"Impatience."

The answer came instantly.

"I knew I was right."

Noah nodded.

"You were."

"Yeah."

"I also knew I was early."

Another nod.

"And instead of respecting the difference between those two things, I convinced myself they were the same thing."

Noah smiled.

Then Elias became serious again.

"I'm not telling you all this because I want you to make the same type of decisions I made."

"I know."

"I'm telling you because I want you to understand how and why I made them."

Noah nodded.

That distinction mattered.

A lot.

Dad had never tried to turn his children into copies of himself.

Quite the opposite.

He seemed almost allergic to the idea.

elias continued : "A father who really loves his son doesn't want a carbon copy."

Noah leaned back.

He had heard pieces of this before.

But never quite this way.

"He wants a man who is better than he ever was."

Elias raised one finger.

"My father was a better man than my grandfather."

then a second finger.

"I became a better man than my father."

finally a third was raised.

"Now I want you to become a better man than me."

For a moment neither spoke.

Finally Noah smiled.

"That's a hell of a standard."

"No."

Elias shook his head.

"It's the only standard that matters."

Several seconds passed.

Then Noah nodded.

"Okay."

"Okay?"

"I'm going to do it."

"The automation project?"

"Yeah."

Elias smiled.

"You already decided before you called me."

"Mostly."

"There it is."

Noah laughed.

"I wanted to see if I was missing anything."

"You are."

"What?"

"You always are."

"Helpful."

"I'm serious."

Elias leaned back.

"If you're waiting until you have all the information, you'll spend your whole life waiting."

Noah nodded slowly.

That sounded exactly like Dad.

Not reckless.

Not impulsive.

Just realistic.

The world rarely offered certainty.

The best decisions were usually made with incomplete information and imperfect timing.

"Think it'll work?"

Elias shrugged.

"I honestly have no idea."

Noah laughed.

Somehow that answer carried more weight than certainty ever could have.

Because if Dad didn't know, then probably nobody knew.

When the call ended, Elias sat quietly for a moment.

Of all the things he had built in his life, Noah and Claire remained the accomplishments he valued most.

Everything else could be debated.

Children could not.

=====

His phone rang less than ten minutes later.

Claire.

Elias smiled.

Apparently it was family morning.

He answered immediately.

"Morning, kiddo."

"Morning, Dad."

Unlike Noah, Claire never sounded like she had just emerged from a twelve-hour manufacturing shift.

She sounded awake.

Alert.

Dangerously intelligent.

A trait she inherited from her mother.

Along with several others that occasionally complicated Elias's life.

"What are we solving today?" he asked.

Claire laughed.

"Why do you assume something needs solving?"

"Because you're calling."

That earned a smile.

Claire had inherited another trait from him.

An unusual relationship with curiosity.

Most people explored subjects.

Claire disappeared into them.

Entire weekends could vanish while she investigated some obscure historical event, scientific paper, economic theory, or technological rabbit hole.

The behavior reminded Elias of somebody.

Though he preferred not to think too carefully about who.

"Still doing your Wikipedia deep dives?" she asked.

"Always."

"Last week you somehow started reading about irrigation systems and ended up researching medieval trade routes."

"It was a logical progression."

"It absolutely was not."

"It made sense at the time."

Claire laughed.

"You know normal people don't do that."

"Normal people watch reality television."

"Good point."

For the next half hour they wandered through a conversation that would have appeared completely incoherent to an outside observer.

Artificial intelligence.

Roman logistics.

The economics of nuclear power.

Ancient shipbuilding.

The decline of local journalism.

Agricultural automation.

Three separate book recommendations.

And somehow, inexplicably, beekeeping.

The topic transitions made perfect sense to both of them.

Neither could have explained why.

Eventually Claire paused.

"Dad?"

"Yeah?"

"I've been thinking about something."

That got his attention.

Claire rarely announced thoughts.

She simply presented them.

"What?"

"Do you ever feel like most people are pretending?"

Elias blinked.

"That's a broad question."

"You know what I mean."

He did.

Unfortunately.

Claire continued.

"Like everybody's following a script they never actually chose."

Elias leaned back in his chair.

The question sounded suspiciously familiar.

Not because he had taught it to her.

Because he had spent decades asking versions of it himself.

"Sometimes."

"Just sometimes?"

"Fine. Frequently."

Claire laughed.

"I knew it."

"You're asking the wrong question."

"I am?"

"Yeah."

"What should I ask?"

Elias thought for a moment.

Then shrugged.

"Ask whether the script works."

Claire was quiet.

"If it does?"

"Use it."

"And if it doesn't?"

"Write a better one."

Several seconds passed.

Finally she laughed.

"That is the most Dad answer possible."

"Thank you."

"It wasn't a compliment."

"I chose to interpret it as one."

"Convenient."

"One of my better qualities."

Claire laughed again.

The conversation drifted onward.

Eventually she had to leave.

Work.

Friends.

Life.

The ordinary obligations of adulthood.

Before hanging up she paused.

"Love you, Dad."

The words arrived so casually that many people would have missed their significance.

Elias never did.

"Love you too, Claire"

The line disconnected.

For a few moments he sat quietly.

Money was useful.

Freedom was useful.

Success was useful.

But none of those things appeared on your deathbed.

People did.

That seemed important.

=====

The nickname had started in Singapore - at least that was where Elias first became aware of it.

"The Magician."

The first time he heard it he assumed somebody was making fun of him.

The second time he heard it he became suspicious.

By the fifth or sixth occurrence he reluctantly accepted that people were serious.

The nickname made him uncomfortable.

Mostly because it wasn't true.

Magic implied mystery.

His experience suggested the opposite.

Most impossible problems became surprisingly ordinary once you understood what was actually causing them.

The challenge was that most people stopped digging too early.

They accepted the first explanation.

The convenient explanation.

The politically acceptable explanation.

The explanation that allowed everyone to avoid responsibility.

Reality rarely cooperated with such arrangements.

The Singapore project had been one example.

A large financial institution had acquired a software platform that was rapidly becoming a disaster.

Schedules slipped.

Costs increased.

Meetings multiplied.

Entire teams of intelligent people spent months explaining why progress was impossible.

Things changed when Elias arrived.

Not because he possessed secret knowledge.

Not because he was smarter than everyone else.

Mostly because he was willing to ask questions nobody else wanted answered.

After several weeks he reached a conclusion.

The technology wasn't the problem.

The people were.

More accurately, the incentives were.

Once that became clear, the technical solution followed surprisingly quickly.

The project eventually succeeded.

Nobody could quite remember why it had seemed impossible.

That happened more often than people realized.

Years later the pattern repeated itself in Alaska.

The Permanent Fund served hundreds of thousands of residents and distributed billions of dollars.

The underlying software was aging.

Replacing it conventionally would have required an army of consultants, years of effort, and extraordinary expense.

Instead Elias and a single junior engineer effectively rebuilt the system from the ground up in less than 18 months. The resulting software codebase was less than 10 percent of the size of the one it replaced - and was at least three times more capable.

It eventually appeared as a Microsoft case study for nearly a decade.

Elias considered that mildly amusing.

Mostly because nobody involved had initially believed the schedule was realistic with such a small team - if you could even call 2 persons a team.

Elias just told them all 'Having more cooks does not guarantee better soup'. And he turned out to be correct.

A problem appeared.

Elias solved it.

Another problem appeared.

Then another.

Eventually enough people started asking for help that a business materialized almost by accident.

He never set out to become an entrepreneur.

His company simply emerged as a side effect of solving problems that other people found difficult.

Looking back, that described much of his career.

Not ambition.

Not status.

Not prestige.

Problems.

Interesting ones.

The kind that forced him to learn something new.

The kind that required understanding reality rather than arguing with it.

The kind that made him curious.

Money occasionally followed.

Recognition sometimes followed.

Neither outcome had ever been the objective.

That was one of the reasons the nickname felt wrong.

Magicians create illusions.

Elias spent most of his life trying to remove them.

=====

Elias sat on his porch that evening enjoying an ice-cold beverage and thinking about the day he just had.

The problem wasn't that life lacked meaning.

The problem was that it contained more meaning than challenge.

Family.

Friends.

Freedom.

Purpose.

He was grateful for all of it.

Yet something still felt unfinished.

As though a question had been asked years ago and never answered.

Elias looked out across the dark pasture.

Surely this could not be the final problem.

Surely there was something bigger.

Something worthy of all the effort.

Something worthy of all the preparation.

Something that mattered.

He finished his last sip of beer and headed inside.

Gaius Cassius Varro

The year was 187 BCE.

Opi was trying very hard not to be noticed.

This was difficult.

Humans had an unfortunate tendency to notice floating metallic spheres.

Especially Roman humans.

Especially Roman humans who had been drinking. A lot.

The man currently stumbling after her through a grove of olive trees was clearly heavily intoxicated.

"Wait."

Opi continued floating away.

"Wait."

She continued floating.

"Wait."

She stopped.

The Roman immediately placed both hands on his hips and smiled triumphantly.

"Aha."

"You have successfully accomplished the difficult task of making me stop moving."

The man beamed.

"I knew it."

Opi had no idea what he was talking about.

The Roman pointed dramatically at himself.

"I am Gaius Cassius Varro."

Opi waited.

The man waited.

Eventually Opi said:

"Is there more?"

His smile faded.

"There is quite a lot more."

"I suspected as much."

"I am a poet."

"That explains several things."

"A philosopher."

"Does it?"

"A soldier."

"No."

"A statesman."

"Definitely not."

"A great and fabulous lover."

Opi paused.

"Of course you are."

Gaius nodded.

"Many women have said so."

"I strongly suspect that number is smaller than you believe."

The Roman laughed loudly.

Far too loudly.

Several birds fled nearby trees.

Opi had been observing humanity for centuries.

She had met kings.

Generals.

Scholars.

Priests.

Gaius Cassius Varro possessed less self-awareness than all of them combined.

Yet she found herself oddly interested in him.

Humans were frequently entertaining.

This one was exceptional.

The Roman began circling her.

Studying her.

"You need a name."

"I already possess a designation."

"A proper Latin name fit for a respected citizen of the Roman empire."

Opi considered this.

The designation was approximately seventeen syllables long in the original Velhari language.

He might have a point.

"What would you suggest?"

Gaius smiled.

The smile of a man about to say something he considered brilliant.

"Opifera."

Opi processed the word.

"Meaning?"

"The Bringer."

"The Bringer of what?"

Gaius waved his hand.

"Things."

"Things."

"Important things."

"That is not a useful description."

The Roman stared and her and Opi could see him visibly attempt to concentrate

Dei Opifera Vis he finally intoned

"It sounds impressive - what does it mean.

the roman screwed up his forehead and grandly said

Dei Opifera Vis - the bringer of divine solace and strength

then he took another drink and said or

"she who carries the weight"

"of what" opi asked

He pointed dramatically toward the sky.

"the world"

It fits you perfectly

"You arrive from nowhere."

He pointed at her.

"You know everything."

He pointed at himself.

"I am clearly destined for greatness."

"Clearly."

"So naturally the gods sent you."

"They did not."

"They absolutely did."

"They absolutely did not."

Gaius ignored this.

"Therefore."

He spread his arms.

"You are Opifera."

Opi considered the matter.

The name was irrational.

Poorly justified.

Linguistically imprecise.

Entirely based upon the assumptions of a very intoxicated man.

She rather liked it.

"Very well."

The Roman's face lit up.

"Excellent."

"You understand this does not make you correct."

"It makes me completely correct."

"It does not."

"It does."

"It does not."

"It does."

Opi floated away.

The Roman followed.

Still talking.

Still explaining why history would remember him forever.

Still completely convinced of his own importance.

More than nineteen centuries later, Opi remembered almost every detail of that conversation.

She remembered his laugh.

His optimism.

His absurd confidence.

His terrible poetry.

She remembered the day he died.

She remembered attending the funeral from a distance.

She remembered being surprised by how sad she felt.

History, as it happened, did not remember Gaius Cassius Varro at all.

The man had been wrong about many things.

Almost everything, really.

But not quite everything.

Two thousand years later she was still using the name he had given her.

Opifera.

The Bringer of Things.

Important Things.